been marked wrongly, giving it a north-south alignment as against the west-east lie of the land. The only other ‘map’ of the area was a sketch drawn by an Assam Rifles NCO who had accompanied Captain Mahabir Prasad during the setting up of the Dhola post. On this sketch, owing to the fact that the sheet of paper was not big enough, the western extremity of the Nam Ka Chu (the hut at Tsangle) was squeezed into the corner, giving the impression that the upper reaches were just a stone’s throw away from Bridge 4. In reality, the distance between Bridge 4 and Bridge 5 at Tsangle took two days of hard marching to traverse.

After reaching the Nam Ka Chu Valley, Mishra had deployed 9 Punjab on the riverfront itself, though a platoon was also occupying the Tsangdhar Ridge that overlooked Bridge 3 and Bridge 4. These were not bridges in the conventional sense, but just logs tied together to help herders get their yaks across and as such had no tactical importance. Battalion HQ along with two companies were at Bridge 2, while one company held Bridge 1. The fourth company along with a platoon of Assam Rifles was holding Bridge 3 and Bridge 4. The fifty-odd Chinese troops were camping across the river beyond Bridge 3. Sadly, this tactically unsound position would remain the alignment of the Indian defences on the Nam Ka Chu in the days to come.

Tsangdhar had an area that was 110 metres by 36 metres on which Mishra felt the IAF could attempt dropping supplies, as this would cut short the long haul from Lumpu. This flat area was also ideally suited for the deployment of heavy mortars and artillery. The request for an ad hoc DZ (drop zone) to be set up at Tsangdhar was sent back up the chain of command and it went through to the highest echelons at record speed. Within twenty-four hours, this thin strip of land at Tsangdhar was designated as a forward DZ and the IAF was told to start using it immediately. If retrievals at Lumpu were pathetic, the recovery of drops at Tsangdhar was even worse, as most of the loads dumped by the Dakotas and Fairchild Packets fell into the ravines and were not recoverable.

While Mishra was briefing Dalvi about the lie of the ground at Bridge 3, they received the signal issued by Army HQ ordering 9 Punjab to capture Thagla and contain Yumtso-la and Karpo-la 2 by 19 September. The brigade commander immediately countermanded the impractical order. Dalvi then spent the next two days doing a reconnaissance of the area west of Bridge 3, going beyond Bridge 4 up to where Log Bridge and Temporary Bridge would come up later. On 21 September he left 9 Punjab’s location and fell